THE U-BOAT WAR



CONVOY ONS-5

Date	April 28–May 6, 1943
Location	North Atlantic
Result	Allied victory

COMBATANTS

UK AND ALLIES	GERMANY

COMMANDERS

Peter Gretton, Robert Sherwood	**Admiral Karl Dönitz**

FORCES

Ships: 12 escort ships	**Ships:** 58 U-boats

LOSSES

Ships: 13 merchant ships sunk	**Ships:** 6 U-boats sunk

CONVOY ONS-5

In spring 1943 a convoy of 43 merchant ships left Liverpool bound for Halifax, Nova Scotia. It was escorted by Group B-7, consisting of two destroyers, a frigate, and four corvettes under the command of Commander Peter Gretton. Convoy ONS-5 was always a sitting target for Admiral Dönitz's U-boat "wolf packs" swarming in the North Atlantic, the more so because the Allied codebreakers were temporarily unable to decipher German messages.

On April 28, ONS-5 was spotted by U-650, one of 16 boats strung out in a line between Greenland and Iceland. Tracking the convoy, U-650 called in the other U-boats for a group attack. Aware of the U-boats' presence through "huff-duff" (HF/DF) radio detection equipment, Gretton organized his defense well—the convoy suffered small losses, while two U-boats were severely damaged. Bad weather then led to an intermission. Reinforcements arrived for the convoy escort, but Gretton's destroyer *Duncan* was forced to leave, unable to refuel in the heavy seas.

THE SECOND ENGAGEMENT

Command passed to Lieutenant Commander Robert Sherwood on the frigate *Tay*. By the time the storm abated on May 4, the main convoy had been reduced to 30 merchant ships with the rest detached stragglers.

The U-boats reformed a line of 29 vessels into which the convoy now blundered. Behind this lay a further line of 24 U-boats. Taken together it was the largest concentration of force Dönitz had ever achieved. He told his U-boat commanders to "fight with everything you've got." On the night of May 4–5 the onslaught on ONS-5 began. It lasted more than 30 hours. U-boats preyed upon the stragglers and worked their way into the middle of the main convoy, sending a number of ships to the bottom with torpedoes. But the escorts fought back tirelessly with a well-rehearsed sweep, using radar and ASDIC (sonar) to locate targets and depth-charges or ramming to attack them. On the night of May 5–6 fog set in. The convoy escorts could see the U-boats on their radar screens, while the U-boat commanders could see neither their targets nor their pursuers.

By daybreak on May 6, ONS-5 had lost 13 merchant ships, but the cost to the U-boats had been high—six boats sunk and at least four severely damaged.

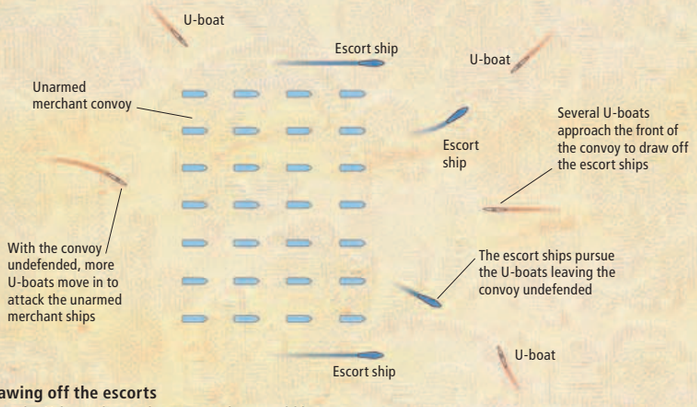


U-BOAT TACTICS

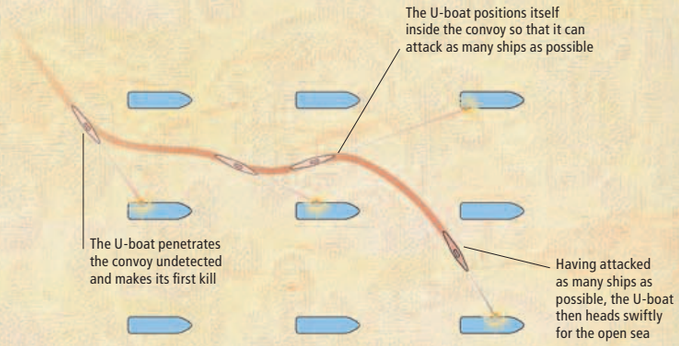
WOLF PACKS

WORKING TOGETHER TO LOCATE AND ATTACK CONVOYS

The "wolf pack" was a group of U-boats hunting together to locate and attack convoys. Typically the U-boats formed a line spread out across an Atlantic convoy route. When one of them spotted a convoy it tracked it, radioing the location to headquarters, which directed other U-boats to join in the hunt. When the pack had assembled around a convoy, the U-boats waited for nightfall and then surfaced to attack. The boldest of them would penetrate the escort screen into the heart of the convoy, picking targets to torpedo at will. The rest fired their torpedoes from outside the convoy. Escort ships were frequently overwhelmed by the number of attackers and, at first, had little chance of spotting low-lying U-boats on the water's surface at night. However, wolf-pack tactics required much use of radio, which allowed the U-boats to be located by escort ships' "huff-duff" (HF/DF) radio direction finders. The subsequent introduction of shipborne radar transformed the ability of escort ships to cope with night surface attacks.



Drawing off the escorts
Once the U-boats located a convoy, they would be directed to assemble around it. The first wave of U-boats was often able to draw off the escort ships, leaving the convoy undefended against attack by other U-boats.



Surfacing inside the convoy
Once a convoy was exposed, the most effective strategy involved the U-boat surfacing inside the convoy before torpedoing individual ships. Accompanying U-boats might fire a spread of torpedoes from outside the convoy.